understood the disappointment of England being knocked out of the World Cup, but some of the stuff that was written—particularly that first morning after the Argentina game—lit a fuse with some people. For them, hatred seemed contagious.

Of course, I was away on the other side of the Atlantic but that didn't stop other people getting put under pressure instead of me. I talked to Mum and Dad: by the time they got back to London from Saint-Etienne, there were already more than thirty people camped outside the house. The phone was being bugged, they had camera crews in their faces every time they opened the front door. The press even set up a little table and chairs with coffee and tea for themselves on the pavement. They were there all the time I was with Victoria in the States. I'd already started to get used to that kind of attention from my life with Victoria. For my parents, it was something completely new and it wasn't as if it had been them who had been sent off at a World Cup. It was a real test for both of them but, because they were there for each other, they had the strength to see it through. Even now they haven't told me the half of what went on during those first few days after the Argentina game. Maybe they don't want me to know. Maybe they don't want to think about it themselves ever again. For all that I've put that time behind me now, some of it still haunts me: my face as a dart board, the effigy hanging from a lamp-post, the staged interviews with supporters.

'Beckham's a disgrace to his country. He should never play for England again.'

A lot of what was said and written about me appeared on the front pages, the news pages, and didn't come from soccer writers, although one or two of them were pretty vindictive too. I've got all of it filed away. It's not a black book or anything but, if you're saving stuff, you need to save it all. My parents' house was always full of clippings waiting to go into scrapbooks. We've collected them all since I was a boy. One or two people have come out since 1998 and said they regretted their part in what happened. The Editor of the *Mirror*, Piers Morgan, whose paper ran the dart board thing, has been honest enough to admit they went too far. I remember the other things that really hurt at the time, and just hope the journalists who wrote them do as well. It's strange now, as England captain, when I'm up front at press conferences. I think I've got a decent relationship with the guys who cover the national side and I'm proud to be talking to them on behalf of my team-mates. A lot of those same journalists were around during that summer five years ago, and I'm sure they remember, as I do, what it was like between the media and me back then. After I arrived back in England, I made a point of